Mansfield Park

A simplified retelling

Original story by Jane Austen

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. A place in someone else’s house

Fanny Price was ten when she left her crowded family home in Portsmouth to live with wealthy relatives at Mansfield Park. Her aunt, Lady Bertram, spent much of her time resting. Sir Thomas Bertram expected order and good behaviour. Another aunt, Mrs Norris, regularly reminded Fanny that she had received a great favour.

The Bertram children had advantages Fanny had never known. Tom, the eldest, enjoyed spending money. Maria and Julia were proud of their education and position. Only Edmund, the younger son, noticed how frightened Fanny was.

He asked about her family and encouraged her to read. His kindness helped her feel less alone. As they grew older, her gratitude became love, though she kept it to herself.

Fanny was quiet, but she observed carefully. Being treated as less important did not prevent her from noticing when people were unfair or careless.

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2. New neighbours

While Sir Thomas was away managing his property in Antigua, Henry and Mary Crawford arrived in the neighbourhood. They were charming, confident and used to fashionable society.

Edmund became attracted to Mary. She liked him too, but disliked his plan to become a clergyman. She hoped he would choose a career that brought more money and social importance.

Henry gave his attention to both Maria and Julia. Maria was already engaged to Mr Rushworth, a wealthy man she did not greatly respect. Henry’s interest made her wish she were free to choose differently.

During a visit to Rushworth’s estate at Sotherton, Fanny watched the little divisions within the group. Maria and Henry slipped away together beyond a locked gate. Edmund and Mary talked privately. People who seemed relaxed and playful were making choices that could hurt others.

Fanny did not know how to stop any of it. Her concern was easily mistaken for shyness.

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3. The private theatre

Tom proposed putting on a play at Mansfield. The young people were excited. Fanny was uncomfortable with the particular play they chose and with the intimate scenes that some of the performers would rehearse.

She refused to act, although Mrs Norris criticised her. Edmund also objected at first. Then he agreed to take a role so that Mary would not have to act opposite a stranger.

Fanny saw how easily a reason could be found for doing something one had already judged unwise.

Sir Thomas returned unexpectedly. He was displeased with the changes to his house and ended the performance. Henry left soon afterwards without proposing to Maria.

Maria had an opportunity to reconsider her own engagement. Sir Thomas offered to release her from it. Hurt by Henry’s departure and eager for independence, she chose to marry Rushworth. Julia went away with the newly married couple, and Mansfield grew quieter.

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4. An unwelcome proposal

Henry returned and decided to make Fanny fall in love with him. Her reserve made the idea interesting to him. But as he spent time with her, his feelings became more serious.

He helped Fanny’s beloved brother William gain a promotion in the navy. Fanny was deeply grateful. Then Henry proposed marriage.

She refused.

Sir Thomas could not understand. Henry offered wealth, attention and an important position. Fanny had very little money of her own. Why would she reject such an opportunity?

She could not tell him every reason without exposing Maria’s behaviour. But she remembered Henry’s carelessness towards the sisters, and she did not trust him as a husband. She also loved Edmund, who continued to hope that Mary would marry him.

Fanny’s relatives treated her refusal as ingratitude or confusion. She found it difficult to defend a choice that

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was clear within her but unpopular with everyone around her.

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5. Portsmouth

Sir Thomas sent Fanny to visit her family in Portsmouth. He hoped that the discomfort of their home would make Henry’s offer more attractive.

Fanny was happy to see them, especially William before he left again for sea. Yet home was noisy, crowded and difficult. Her mother was exhausted, her father was rough in his manners, and there was little space for quiet thought.

Her younger sister Susan became her companion. Fanny helped her find books and tried to make their shared surroundings more comfortable.

Henry visited and behaved considerately. For a time, Fanny could imagine that he might truly change. Still, she did not promise to marry him. A few good days could not answer every question about his character.

In letters, Mary continued to describe Edmund’s career as something disappointing. Fanny hoped he would eventually see the difference between Mary’s charm and the values he wanted in a wife.

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6. The family’s crisis

News from Mansfield became alarming. Tom was seriously ill after a period of careless living. Then came a worse shock: Maria had left her husband with Henry Crawford.

The affair became public. Julia had also run away to marry Mr Yates, partly to avoid the strict control she expected after her sister’s disgrace.

Henry’s promise to become a different man had failed when his vanity was challenged. Maria’s marriage had not freed her from the desire to be admired by him.

Mary spoke of the affair mainly as a social disaster that might have been managed if nobody had discovered it. Edmund was horrified. He had expected sorrow for the harm done, not merely regret about exposure.

At last, he understood how far apart their values were. Their relationship ended.

Edmund came to bring Fanny back to Mansfield. Susan went with them. Fanny returned to a troubled household, but she was no longer regarded as someone whose

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opinion could be dismissed so easily.

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7. A different future

Maria and Henry did not make a lasting life together. Maria’s marriage ended, and Mrs Norris went to live with her elsewhere. Sir Thomas recognised that the education of his daughters had given too much attention to appearances and too little to character.

Tom recovered and became more responsible. Julia’s marriage was eventually accepted. Susan found a useful and more comfortable place at Mansfield.

Fanny listened while Edmund recovered from his disappointment. He had long trusted her, but had not understood the depth of that trust. Gradually, affection grew into love.

They married and built a life suited to their values. Fanny’s happiness did not come because she had learned to impress everyone. It came partly because she had refused to surrender her judgement when doing so would have been easier.

Mansfield had given her shelter and education. In return, the quiet girl had helped its owner understand something about what a home should teach.

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Words to keep

Reserve — a habit of keeping your thoughts and feelings private. Henry found Fanny’s reserve unusual.

Vanity — too much concern with being admired. Henry’s vanity helped lead him into trouble.

Gratitude — appreciation for kindness or help. Fanny felt gratitude without agreeing to marry Henry.

Principle — a belief that guides your choices. She refused to act against her principles.

Exposure — the discovery of something previously hidden. Mary worried about exposure more than the harm itself.

Integrity — being honest and consistent with your values. Fanny showed integrity under pressure.

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A question to carry with you

Can you appreciate someone’s help and still say no to what they ask in return? How would you explain that distinction?

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